and transformed it into a paean to non-violence and truth. It was quite a feat (what some have seen as a creative 'misreading' of the text),[19] that located his Hinduism on a platform of *ahimsa* and *satya*, and at the same time anchored his political strategy in the Hindu faith of the masses.

And even while doing so, Gandhi took care to include Indians of other faiths in his capacious and agglomerative version of Hinduism. He noted that there is ample religious literature, both in the *astika* and *nastika* religious traditions, that supports a pluralistic approach to religious and cultural diversity. Gandhi found support for his Advaitist beliefs not only in the Vedanta but in the Jain concept of 'Anekantavada'—the notion that truth and reality are perceived differently by different people from their own different points of view, and that therefore no single perception can constitute the complete truth—from which he derived the axiom that 'truth is many-sided and relative'. Gandhi often expressed the view that the spirit of synthesis was the essential hallmark of Indian civilisation. This led him to declare once, in response to being classified a Hindu: 'I am a Hindu, a Muslim, a Christian, a Parsi, a Jew'. (To which the Muslim League leader Muhammad Ali Jinnah tartly riposted: 'Only a Hindu could say that.')

As a Hindu, I am proud to lay claim to the legacy of the tradition of thought and action that began with the Vedas and grew under Adi Shankara, flowered through Bhakti, embraced social reformers like Raja Rammohan Roy and Sree Narayana Guru, and has Swami Vivekananda and Mahatma Gandhi as two of its fountainheads.